

EPA Compliance Workshops Don't Reduce Violations

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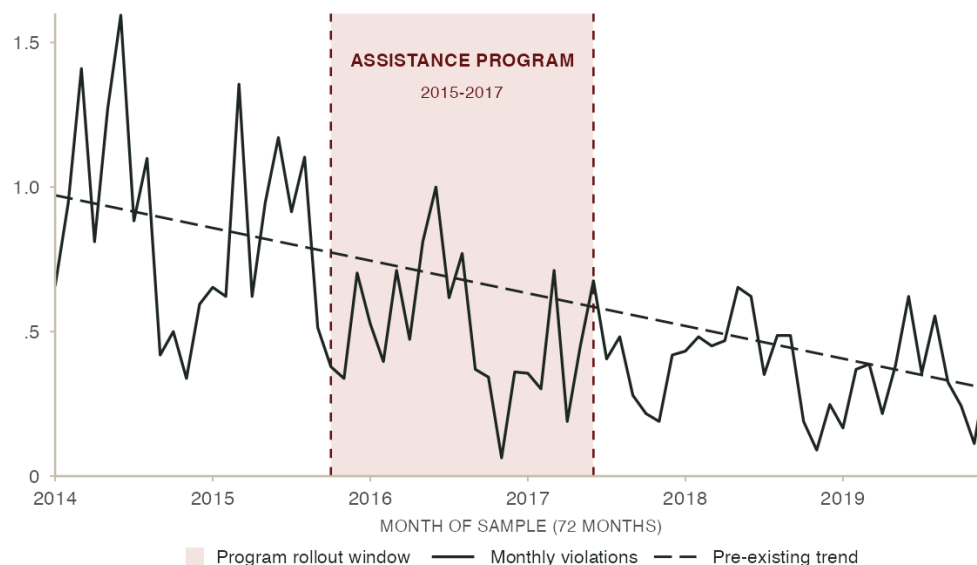
Offering polluters free help to follow environmental rules does not make them more likely to follow them. Researchers studied thousands of facilities that received EPA compliance workshops and found no reduction in violations — the program looked effective at first glance, but the improvement was a pre-existing trend, not caused by the workshops.

BACKGROUND

When a polluting facility breaks environmental rules, the EPA has two main options: levy a fine, or offer a helping hand. For the past decade, the agency has been quietly shifting from the first to the second — cutting back on inspections and penalties in favor of free **compliance assistance**: workshops and consulting designed to help facilities understand and follow the rules. The logic is appealing. But this study asks a question that had never been rigorously tested: does it actually work?

VIOLATIONS PER FACILITY, 2014–2019

Source: Ferraro & Shimshack (2026).



Violations were already falling before the EPA's workshops started — and kept falling at exactly the same rate afterward. The black line shows what actually happened; the dashed line shows the trend that was already in motion beforehand. The two never separate. If the workshops worked, the black line would have dropped below the dashed one.

TAKEAWAY

Before trading a proven enforcement tool for a newer alternative, **test whether the alternative actually works**. Inspections and penalties have a strong track record of reducing violations; compliance assistance does not. With EPA enforcement resources under pressure, scaling an unproven program comes at a real cost. The EPA has the data to run this kind of evaluation — this study is a model for how it should be done, and a reminder that good intentions are not a substitute for evidence.